The Antihero

By Ai

INTRODUCTION

When we hear the word 'hero,' certain images come to mind: Superman swooping in to save Lois Lane; Harry Potter sacrificing himself to rescue his friends; Simba from The Lion King and William Wallace from Braveheart. But what if Superman had acne and had a hard time getting the girl or Harry Potter suffered from OCD? What if Simba was too afraid to take on the villain Scar and instead was filled with self-doubt? Enter the anti-hero -- a notable figure who is conspicuously lacking in heroic qualities. In other words, he is flawed. It is this flaw or weakness that leads to his downfall, destruction, and usually death.

Meet our Antihero . . . On April 19, 1995, he ran back and forth into the concrete mess of bricks and mortar that was once the Murrah Building in Oklahoma City. He scraped and crawled and dug until his fingers bled and then kept digging some more. But just over a year later, 30-year-old Terry Yeakey was gone – a victim of what was officially deemed as "Suicide" only four days before he was to receive a medal of honor for rescuing people after the Oklahoma City bombing.

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I park my old maroon Ford in the field outside El Reno,
where wildflowers used to grow, when I was a kid,
but now only thorny memories push their heads
through the dirt like misplaced cacti.
At first, I just sit in the dark,
my heart racing,
then I take my Swiss Army Knife
and slit my wrists.
As blood runs down my hands, I feel exhilarated,
until I remember who I am --
a man with rat's eyes,
pink rimmed and sensitive to light.
When I was born,
the doctor pronounced me "albino."
I'm told my mother said,
"They run in the family,
but he's all right, he's my baby."
Six months later, I was adopted by another,
who loved me even though I wasn't an albino after all.
Much like a Siamese, who are born white,
parts of my body began to darken

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until I looked like any other boy.
When I was nine, Widow Dobbs, who lived next door,
brought home a Siamese.
She named him Buster Kitty.
He was a big, round-headed cat,
who hunted birds and tormented dogs,
when he wasn't sitting outside my window,
looking in at me,
as if I were a long-lost relative.
We respected each other,
but avoided too much contact.
When I went outside to play, he'd stroll away,
his tail lifted in the air, as if to say, "Take that."
One afternoon, he got run over by a moving van.
Widow Dobbs wasn't home and neither was my mother,
so I carried him to our backyard
and buried him in a hole I dug with a garden trowel.
I didn't tell anyone I'd done it.
After a week, the widow put up signs
offering a reward.
A few months later,

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A stray dog dug up Buster's skeleton.
"I suppose you know nothing about it," said Mother.
"A truck hit him, he was dead, so I buried him," I
confessed,
but Mother only said "I found your water pistol."
Now Buster sits on my shoulder,
whispering that I'll get what I deserve.
I tell him I always do.
I used to see him two, or three times a day,
when I was a military policeman,
during the Persian Gulf War.
That's when I helped bury civilians in mass graves.
The corpses gave off the smell of chemicals and oil
and when I washed my hands,
a black film came off on my Handi Wipes.
There, as the smoke from the burning oil wells
blackened the light of each day.,
I picked up the carcasses of birds
overcome by fumes,
having dropped from the air
after dying in midflight.

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I buried them too,
as Buster scolded me about how I placed the bodies.
"No," he'd say, "don't drop them in like stones
down the well of death,"
And I didn't. I laid them down gently
like a mother, who has found her lost children.
After a while, he simply faded
into the scenery of that endless night
and when I went home to Oklahoma City,
he kept his distance.
It was enough to convince me that I was free of him,
until the day the Murrah building was bombed.
I was a policeman then too,
because I'd persuaded myself
it was the best way to help people.
That morning, I pulled three men and two women
from the rubble,
before I fell through a hole two floors
and lay helpless in the debris.
As body fluids dripped on me, Buster appeared,
but he didn't say anything,

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only hovered in the air, until I passed out.
After I came home from the hospital,
my back hurt constantly
and I had nightmares about dead children.
I was afraid of what I might do,
without knowing what it was.
Waves of nausea often sent me to the bathroom,
Where I kneeled in front of the toilet,
until a vile liquid bubbled up
from the pit of my stomach.
It tasted like green chilies
and burned the back of my throat.
I pissed blood and cursed Buster,
who truly knew me for what I was,
because I was to blame for his death
and hid my shame by covering it with dirt.
The day he died, I shot him with my water pistol.
That's when he darted in the path
of a Bekins truck.
That night, I made a promise to myself
that I would be of help to anyone who needed it.

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Now as I listen to the drip, drip of my blood,
hitting the rubber floor mat and my shoes,
I realize I can't rescue the dead,
or erase the zero of my life
and make it count,
when all it amounts to is a few pints of blood
turning to red mud,
as I stagger from the car to a gully nearby.
I kneel down and lay my Bible
and copy of *In Their Names* on the ground,
As Buster reappears to tell me it's all right,
I won't feel a thing,
but we both know he's lying
and when I raise my revolver to my head and fire,
a wave of desire washes over me
and I understand that what I always wanted
was release from my own pain,
but there's only the terrible surrender to it,

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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